

RTL Design Sherpa

CDC Counter Display Nexys A7 Project Guide 0.90

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Table of Contents

1 Document Information....9
1.1 References....9
1.2 Conventions....9
1.3 Revision History....10
2 Overview....11
2.1 What it is....11
2.1.1 Figure 1.1: CDC Demo Harness Spine....11
2.2 What it demonstrates....12
2.3 What you need....12
2.4 Where things live....12
3 How It Works....13
3.1 Top-level structure (cdc_demo_top)....13
3.2 Clocking and the four source clocks....13
3.3 One counter domain (cdc_counter_domain)....14
3.4 The five CDC modes (CDC_MODE)....14
3.5 Display....15
4 Test Methodology....16
4.1 What is under test....16
4.2 What is measured, and how....16
4.3 Workloads....16
4.4 The oracle, and what sim can/can't show....17
4.5 Measurement pitfalls....17

5 Build and Run....18
5.1 The workflow at a glance....18
5.2 Make targets....18
5.2.1 Simulation....18
5.2.2 Register collateral....18
5.2.3 Bitstream....19
5.3 The host CLI (build-demo/host/host_cdc_demo.py)....19
5.3.1 The “watch it fail” procedure....20
6 Harness CSR Configuration....21
6.1 Global registers....22
6.2 Per-counter block....23
6.3 By-name access....24
6.4 Regenerating the regmap....25
7 Simulation / Silicon Equivalence....26
7.1 The layered stack (only the bottom layer differs)....26
7.2 How the sim runs the same program....26
7.3 What the sim can and cannot reproduce....27
7.4 Gotchas worth keeping....27
8 Troubleshooting....28
8.1 The host CLI cannot find the board....28
8.2 Values look scrambled / never settle....28
8.3 make lint — Xilinx primitive errors....28
8.4 make sim BUILD=phase1 fails to compile....28
8.5 make consistency fails after editing registers....29

8.6 Sim runs but nothing advances.....29

List of Figures

Figure 1.1: CDC Demo Harness Spine.....11

List of Tables

Table 1: Document references..... 9
Table 2: Revision history..... 10
Table 3: Project file layout..... 12
Table 4: Per-counter clock sources..... 13
Table 5: The five CDC modes for the VALUE readback path..... 14
Table 6: What is measured..... 16
Table 7: Demonstration workloads..... 16
Table 8: Simulation make targets..... 18
Table 9: Register-collateral make targets..... 18
Table 10: Bitstream make targets..... 19
Table 11: Global CSR registers — register / field / offset / bit slice..... 22
Table 12: Per-counter CSR block — counter i absolute offset = 0x40 + i*0x40 + column..... 23

List of Waveforms

Waveform 5.1: AXI4-Lite Single-Beat Write.....22

1 Document Information

This is the operator / developer guide for the Nexys A7 **CDC Counter Display** project (`projects/fpga-systems/NexysA7/misc-ip/cdc_counter_display`). It explains what the project is, how it works, how to build / simulate / program / run it, and how the UART characterization harness is configured. It is a practical guide, not a formal architecture specification.

The project ships in two phases that coexist in the same tree:

- **Phase 1** — a standalone, button-driven CDC counter (`cdc_counter_display_top`).
- **Phase 2** — a UART-controlled, four-counter CDC demonstrator (`cdc_demo_top`) with a host program that runs byte-for-byte identically on the FPGA and in a cocotb simulation. This guide focuses on Phase 2.

1.1 References

Document references

Source	Title
RTL Design Sherpa	`projects/fpga-systems/NexysA7/misc-ip/cdc_counter_display/README.md`
RTL Design Sherpa	`docs/HARNESS.md` (CSR map + wiring)
RTL Design Sherpa	`docs/RUNBOOK.md` (operator procedures)
RTL Design Sherpa	`bin/TBClasses/harness/` (shared UART-char collateral)
Digilent	Nexys A7 Reference Manual
ARM	AMBA AXI and APB Protocol Specifications

1.2 Conventions

- **Registers are accessed by name**, never by hardcoded offset (see Chapter 4).

- **Clock:** `sys_clk` = 100 MHz on-board oscillator. Per-counter source clocks (`ctr_clk[i]`) are asynchronous to `sys_clk` and to each other.
- **Reset:** `CPU_RESETN` (board button BTNR, active-low) or `CTRL.soft_reset`.
- **Register/signal prefixes:** `r_` registered, `w_` combinational.

1.3 Revision History

Revision history

Version	Date	Notes
0.90	2026-07-18	Initial project guide
0.91	2026-10-20	Block diagrams redrawn to the repo element key (v3): class fills, double-bordered registered blocks, green return paths and a generated key under each figure. No technical content changed.

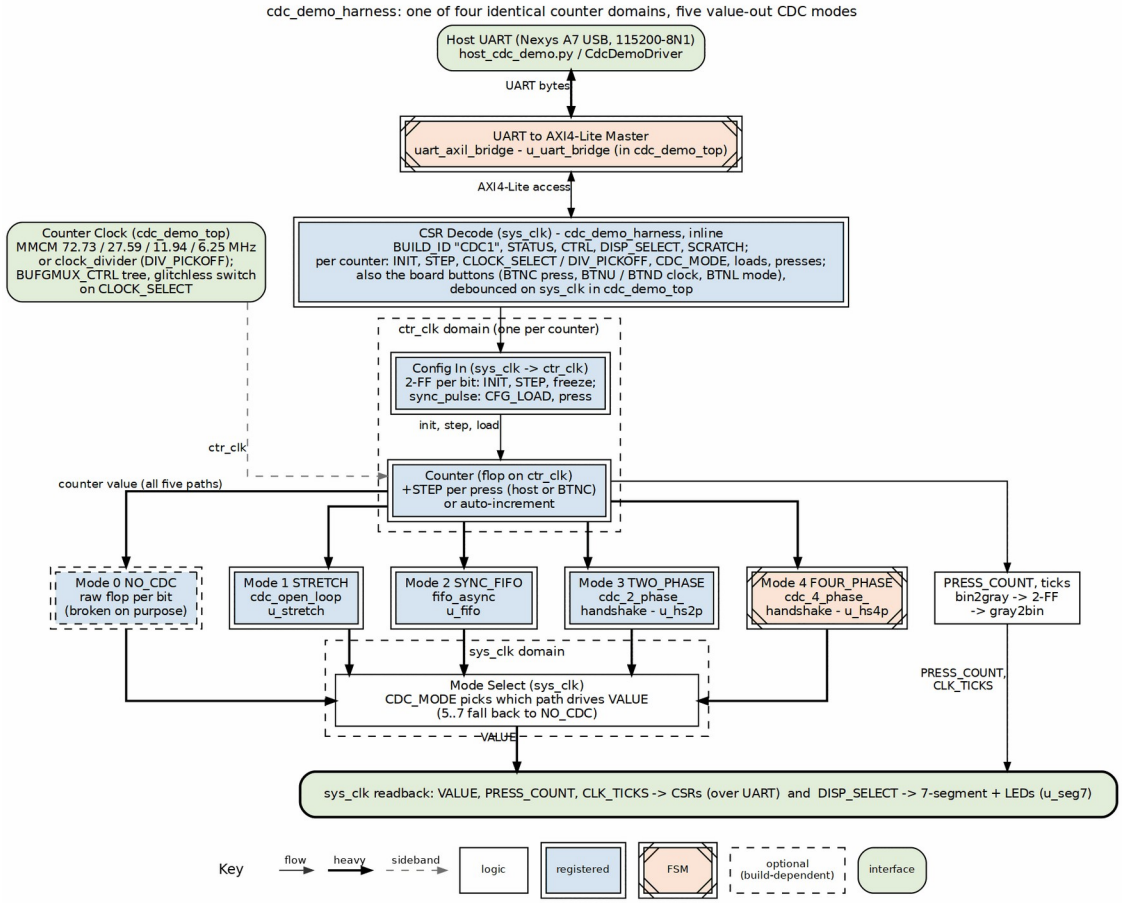
2 Overview

2.1 What it is

CDC Counter Display is an educational Nexys A7 project that demonstrates **clock domain crossing (CDC)** — both done correctly and broken on purpose — on real silicon. Four independent counters each run in their own asynchronous clock domain; a host program over UART configures them, reads their values back across the CDC boundary, and can deliberately select an unsafe crossing to *watch CDC fail* on the 7-segment display.

Phase 2 (`cdc_demo_top`) is wired on the standard Nexys A7 characterization **spine**: a single USB-UART link feeds a `uart_axil_bridge` that converts an ASCII `W/R` command protocol into AXI4-Lite, which drives the `cdc_demo_harness` CSR block. The harness fans configuration out to four `cdc_counter_domain` instances and collects their CDC'd status back.

2.1.1 Figure 1.1: CDC Demo Harness Spine



CDC demo harness spine

Source: 01_harness_spine.dot

2.2 What it demonstrates

- **Safe multi-bit CDC.** With a Gray-coded or FIFO-based crossing, the host reads coherent counter values at any source-clock speed.
- **Broken CDC, visibly.** Put a counter in NO-CDC mode with auto-increment, then sweep its source clock from slow to fast: the display stays clean at low speeds and visibly scrambles at high speeds (multi-bit bus skew), while the other counters — in a safe mode — stay clean the whole time.
- **Five selectable CDC strategies** per counter: NO-CDC, stretch, sync-FIFO, two-phase handshake, four-phase handshake.
- **Sim / silicon equivalence.** The same host program drives the FPGA and a cocotb simulation over the identical UART byte stream (Chapter 6).

2.3 What you need

- Nexys A7-100T board (XC7A100T-1CSG324C) + USB cable.
- Xilinx Vivado (for `make bitstream` / `make program`).
- A Python environment sourced from `env_python` (for the host CLI and sim).

2.4 Where things live

Project file layout

Path	Contents
`build-demo/rtl/cdc_demo_top.sv`	Board top: clocking tree, buttons, harness, display
`build-demo/rtl/cdc_demo_harness.sv`	AXI4-Lite CSR + per-counter fan-out
`build-demo/rtl/cdc_counter_domain.sv`	One counter + its CDC paths (5 modes)
`build-demo/rtl/cdc_demo_csr.rdl`	Register descriptor (generates the by-name regmap)
`build-demo/host/`	`cdc_demo.py` driver, `cdc_programs.py`, `host_cdc_demo.py` CLI
`build-demo/dv/`	UART-equivalence cocotb sim (tb, tests, filelist, regmap)
`Makefile`	Build / sim / program / host targets

3 How It Works

3.1 Top-level structure (cdc_demo_top)

The board top instantiates, from UART inward:

1. **uart_axil_bridge** — decodes the ASCII `W <addr> <data>` / `R <addr>` protocol into single-beat AXI4-Lite. `CLKS_PER_BIT` is derived from `SYS_CLK_HZ / 115200`.
2. **cdc_demo_harness** — the AXI4-Lite CSR slave (Chapter 5). Stores per-counter config, exposes CDC'd status, and generates single-cycle pulses (`CFG_LOAD`, `HOST_PRESS`).
3. **Clocking tree** — an `MMCME2_BASE` produces four co-prime divided clocks; per counter a `BUFGMUX_CTRL` tree glitchlessly selects one of five sources.
4. **Four cdc_counter_domain instances** — the counters and their CDC paths.
5. **Display** — `DISP_SELECT` picks which counter's value drives the 7-seg.

3.2 Clocking and the four source clocks

The MMCM synthesizes four **mutually asynchronous** clocks from the 100 MHz reference using pairwise co-prime divisors, plus a per-counter sys_clk-derived divided clock:

Per-counter clock sources

clock_select	Source	Frequency
0	MMCM CLKOUT0 (÷11)	72.7 MHz
1	MMCM CLKOUT1 (÷29)	27.6 MHz
2	MMCM CLKOUT2 (÷67)	11.9 MHz
3	MMCM CLKOUT3 (÷128)	6.25 MHz
4	`clock_divider` (uses `div_pickoff`)	`sys_clk / 2^(pickoff+1)`

The co-prime divisors `{11, 29, 67, 128}` mean no two outputs share an edge alignment for a very long time — for CDC purposes, truly asynchronous. The divided-clock branch (select 4) keeps

a slow, visibly-counting rate available for the “watch it count” demo; `div_pickoff = 23` gives roughly 6 Hz.

3.3 One counter domain (`cdc_counter_domain`)

Each counter lives entirely in its `ctr_clk[i]` domain and crosses two ways:

- **sys_clk → ctr_clk (config in):** `INIT` / `INCREMENT` as quasi-static 2-FF synchronized buses; `CFG_LOAD` / `HOST_PRESS` as single-shot pulses through a `sync_pulse` module.
- **ctr_clk → sys_clk (status out):** `VALUE`, `PRESS_COUNT`, `CTR_CLK_TICKS` crossed back for readback. **The `VALUE` path is where `CDC_MODE` selects the crossing strategy** — this is the heart of the demo.

On each `ctr_clk` edge the counter loads `INIT` on a `CFG_LOAD` pulse, otherwise advances by `INCREMENT` when a press event occurs. A press event is a debounced button, a `HOST_PRESS` pulse, or — when `AUTO_INC = 1` — every `ctr_clk` edge.

3.4 The five CDC modes (`CDC_MODE`)

The five CDC modes for the VALUE readback path

Mode	Name	Primitive	Safe?
0	NO-CDC	raw flop per bit	No (multi-bit skew at fast clocks)
1	STRETCH	`cdc_open_loop` (pulse stretch + sync)	Up to a tuned cliff (~25 MHz)
2	SYNC-FIFO	`fifo_async` (Gray pointers)	Yes
3	TWO-PHASE	`cdc_2_phase_handshake`	Yes
4	FOUR-PHASE	`cdc_4_phase_handshake`	Yes

Mode 0 (NO-CDC) samples the multi-bit value with plain flops — at a fast source clock the bits arrive skewed and the host reads transient garbage. That is the intended failure. In Verilator (no metastability model) mode 0 reads the true value deterministically, which is why the simulation asserts on mode 0 for exact values (Chapter 6) but the *board* shows scramble at speed.

3.5 Display

`DISP_SELECT` chooses which counter's 16-bit `VALUE` drives the 7-segment digits; the upper digits show the selected counter's `CDC_MODE` and clock-select so the operator can read the current configuration off the board.

4 Test Methodology

This chapter describes what is exercised on the FPGA block (Figure 2.1) and how the results are judged. CDC Counter Display is a **demonstration**, so the "measurement" is a coherence test of the clock-domain-crossing readback rather than a throughput sweep.

4.1 What is under test

The four `cdc_counter_domain` value-readback paths, each selectable among five CDC strategies (`CDC_MODE` 0–4) and driven by an asynchronous source clock whose rate the host can sweep. The question under test: **does the multi-bit counter value cross into `sys_clk` coherently?**

4.2 What is measured, and how

What is measured

Quantity	How it is obtained
Value coherence	Read `VALUE` by name N times; compute min / max / number of unique samples
Press determinism	After `count` `HOST_PRESS` pulses, check `VALUE == INIT + count*INCREMENT` and `PRESS_COUNT` delta
Reload	`CFG_LOAD` reloads `VALUE` to `INIT` without disturbing `PRESS_COUNT`
Mode selection	Each `CDC_MODE` code round-trips through the CSR and selects a distinct path

A run configures a counter (mode, init, increment, clock), injects stimulus (`HOST_PRESS` or `AUTO_INC`), then samples `VALUE`/`PRESS_COUNT` over the by-name bridge. In the "watch-fail" workload the counter is put in NO-CDC with `AUTO_INC = 1` and its source clock is swept slow→fast; the **spread and unique count of the `VALUE` samples** is the metric — a few unique values means clean crossing, a wide 0x00–0xFF spread means multi-bit skew.

4.3 Workloads

Demonstration workloads

Workload	Purpose
`press`	Deterministic increment check (safe CDC mode)
`cfg_load`	Reload semantics
`cdc_mode`	All five mode codes round-trip

Workload	Purpose
`watch_fail`	Sweep an unsafe crossing slow→fast and watch it break

4.4 The oracle, and what sim can/can't show

The oracle is the arithmetic expectation (`INIT + presses*INCREMENT`) for the safe modes. In Verilator the NO-CDC path reads the *true* value (no metastability model), so the sim asserts exact values even in mode 0 — the analog "garbage" is a silicon-only effect. That asymmetry is the point of the demo, not a defect (Chapter 6, Sim Equivalence).

4.5 Measurement pitfalls

- NO-CDC garbage at speed is **expected** — use a safe `CDC_MODE` (2/3/4) before asserting exact values.
- `PRESS_COUNT` always uses Gray-coded CDC and stays coherent regardless of mode; prefer it when you need a trustworthy count.

5 Build and Run

All commands are run from `projects/fpga-systems/NexysA7/misc-ip/cdc_counter_display/` after sourcing the Python environment:

```
cd /path/to/RTLDesignSherpa
source env_python            # sets SIM=verilator, PATH, PYTHONPATH,
REPO_ROOT
cd projects/fpga-systems/NexysA7/misc-ip/cdc_counter_display
```

5.1 The workflow at a glance

```
make regmap  ->  make consistency  ->  make sim        (prove it in
simulation)
                                          |
                                          v
             make bitstream  ->  make program  ->  make host-cdc_demo
(on the board)
```

Targets go to `build-demo` by default; add `BUILD=phase1` for the button-only build. All flow logic lives in the global `make/fpga_flow.mk` (`make targets` lists what was discovered).

5.2 Make targets

5.2.1 Simulation

Simulation make targets

Target	What it does
`make sim BUILD=phase1`	Phase-1 CocoTB sim of `cdc_counter_display_top`.
`make sim`	**UART-equivalence** sim: wraps the real `uart_axil_bridge` + harness and runs the host programs over a cocotb UART master (`build-demo/dv/tests/test_cdc_demo_uart.py`). Four tests: smoke, press, cfg_load, cdc_mode.

5.2.2 Register collateral

Register-collateral make targets

Target	What it does
`make regmap`	Regenerate `build-demo/dv/tbclasses/cdc_demo_csr_regmap.py` from `build-demo/rtl/cdc_demo_csr.rdl`.

Target	What it does
	Run after editing the RDL — never hand-edit the regmap.
`make consistency`	Guard test: the generated regmap must match the hand-written `cdc_demo_harness.sv` (offsets + per-counter block).

5.2.3 Bitstream

Bitstream make targets

Target	What it does
`make bitstream`	Build the demo bitstream `build-demo/fpga/bitstream/cdc_demo.bit` with Vivado (~5–10 min). `make project` creates the Vivado project only; `make synth` stops after synthesis.
`make program`	Flash the board (shared board layer, registry-pinned JTAG serial). `make ports` / `make board-info` inspect the board.
`make lint`	Verilator lint of the build's filelist closure (Xilinx clocking primitives are stubbed — see Chapter 7).
`make utilization` / `make timing`	Print the latest report summaries.
`make keep`	Promote the current bitstream + reports out of the clean blast radius.

5.3 The host CLI (`build-demo/host/host_cdc_demo.py`)

The CLI builds a `CdcDemoDriver`, resolves the serial port through the shared board layer (narrows to this board's ports by USB serial, then probes for the `CDC1` build ID unless `--port` is given), and dispatches to the authored-once programs in `cdc_programs.py`. Run it as `make host-cdc_demo ARGS=...` or directly:

```
# Verify the link and dump all four counters' defaults
make host-cdc_demo ARGS=smoke

# Inject 1000 host presses to counter 2; checks VALUE = INIT +
1000*INCREMENT
make host-cdc_demo ARGS="press --counter 2 --count 1000"
```

```
# CFG_LOAD reload check / CDC_MODE round-trip
make host-cdc_demo ARGS="cfg-load --counter 1"
make host-cdc_demo ARGS="cdc-mode --counter 0"

# Real-time monitor of all four counters
make host-cdc_demo ARGS=monitor

# The headline demo: NO-CDC + auto-increment, sweep the clock slow ->
fast
make host-cdc_demo ARGS="watch-fail --counter 2"

# Force a specific port instead of autodetect (direct invocation)
python3 build-demo/host/host_cdc_demo.py --port /dev/ttyUSB1 smoke
```

Each subcommand prints a human-readable result and returns a non-zero exit code on failure, so the CLI doubles as a board bring-up smoke test.

5.3.1 The “watch it fail” procedure

1. Program the board (`make program`).
2. `make host-cdc_demo ARGS="watch-fail --counter 2"` sets counter 2 to NO-CDC + auto-increment, sets `DISP_SELECT` to 2, and sweeps `div_pickoff` from slow to fast, sampling `VALUE` at each step.
3. Read the on-board 7-seg: clean counting at slow pickoffs, visible scramble at fast pickoffs. Compare against a counter left in a safe mode — it stays clean.

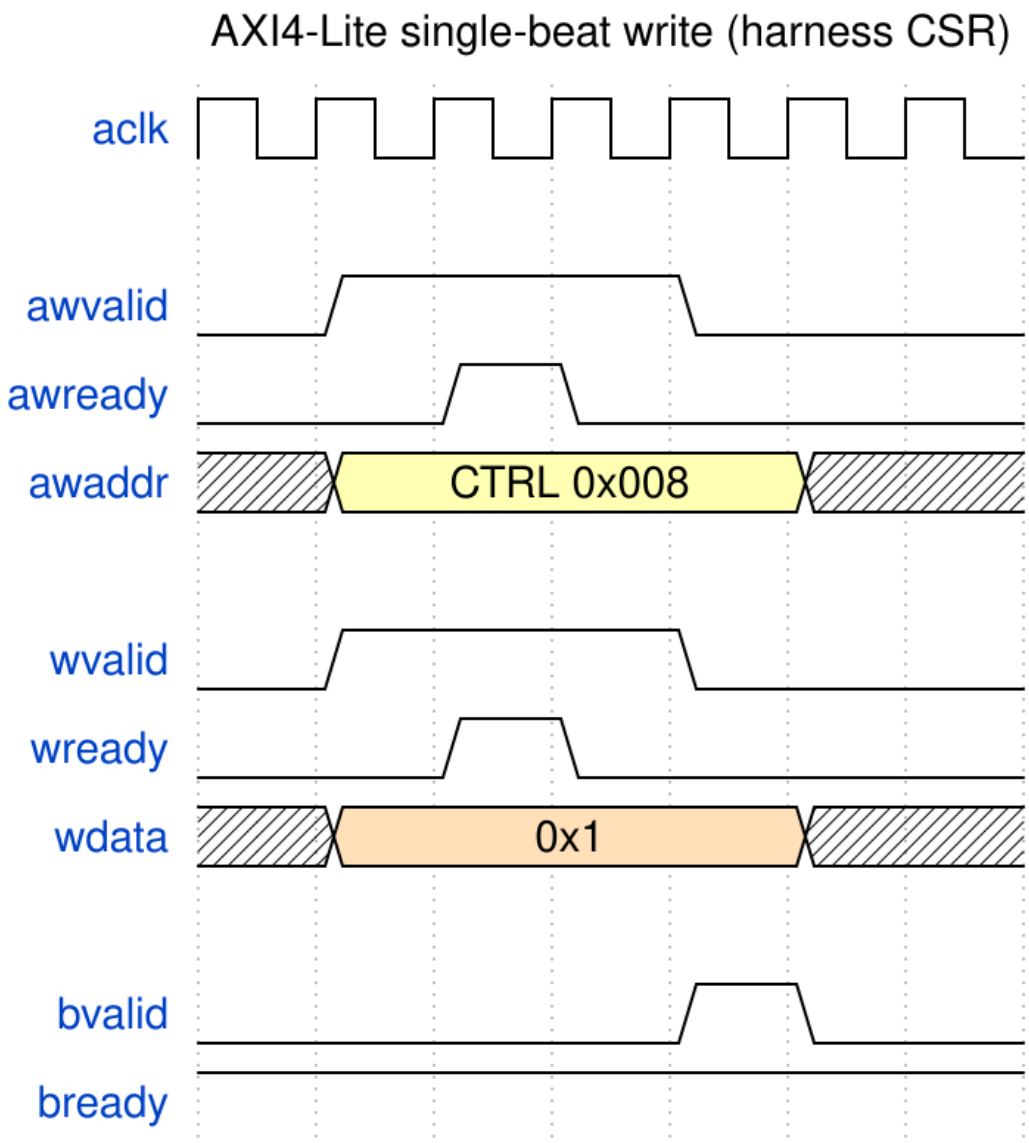
6 Harness CSR Configuration

The `cdc_demo_harness` is a single flat AXI4-Lite slave. The host reaches it through the UART bridge at **harness base `0x0`**. Every register is 32 bits, word-addressable.

Registers are accessed by name, never by offset. The layout is authoritative in `rtl/cdc_demo_harness.sv`, described in `rtl/cdc_demo_csr.rdl`, and compiled to `dv/tbclasses/cdc_demo_csr_regmap.py` (PeakRDL). The driver, the host programs, and the sim all resolve names through that regmap; the `consistency` test guards the three against drift.

Every named write becomes a single AXI4-Lite beat that the UART bridge drives into the harness (a named read is the mirror AR/R exchange):

6.0.0.1 Waveform 5.1: AXI4-Lite Single-Beat Write



AXI4-Lite single-beat write

Source: 01_axil_write.json

6.1 Global registers

Global CSR registers — register / field / offset / bit slice

Register	Offset	Field	Bits	Access	Description
BUILD_ID	0x000	value	[31:0]	R	ASCII “CDC1”

Register	Offset	Field	Bits	Access	Description
					(0x43434331) — read first to confirm the bitstream
STATUS	0x004	alive0–alive3	[3:0]	R	Counter *i* toggled within the last ~1 s window
STATUS	0x004	uart_rx	[4]	R	UART RX activity
STATUS	0x004	uart_tx	[5]	R	UART TX activity
STATUS	0x004	any_written	[6]	R	Any CSR written since reset
STATUS	0x004	reset_ok	[31]	R	Reset deasserted / harness alive
CTRL	0x008	soft_reset	[0]	RW	Pulse: full sys_clk reset
CTRL	0x008	freeze	[1]	RW	Freeze all counters
CTRL	0x008	ignore_btn	[2]	RW	Ignore physical buttons (host-press only)
DISP_SELECT	0x00C	sel	[1:0]	RW	Which counter drives the 7-seg
SCRATCH	0x010	value	[31:0]	RW	Link-sanity scratch (write, read back)

6.2 Per-counter block

Counter `i` (0–3) occupies `0x040 + i*0x40`. The regmap keys are `COUNTER{i}_<REG>` (e.g. `COUNTER2_DIVISOR`).

*Per-counter CSR block — counter i absolute offset = 0x40 + i*0x40 + column*

Register	+Offset	Field	Bits	Access	Description
DIVISOR	+0x00	clock_select	[2:0]	RW	Clock source (0–3 MMCM, 4 =

Register	+Offset	Field	Bits	Access	Description
					divided)
DIVISOR	+0x00	div_pickoff	[12:8]	RW	Divided-clock pickoff (when clock_select=4)
INIT	+0x04	value	[15:0]	RW	Value loaded by CFG_LOAD
INCREMENT	+0x08	value	[15:0]	RW	Advance amount per press
CFG_LOAD	+0x0C	strobe	[0]	W	Pulse: load INIT into the counter
HOST_PRESS	+0x10	strobe	[0]	W	Pulse: inject one virtual press
VALUE	+0x14	value	[15:0]	R	Current value, CDC'd per CDC_MODE
PRESS_COUNT	+0x18	value	[15:0]	R	Debounced press count (always Gray-CDC'd)
CTR_CLK_TICKS	+0x1C	value	[31:0]	R	Free-running ctr_clk tick count
CDC_MODE	+0x20	mode	[2:0]	RW	CDC strategy for VALUE (0–4; see Chapter 2)
AUTO_INC	+0x24	en	[0]	RW	1 = advance every ctr_clk edge

6.3 By-name access

The driver (host/cdc_demo.py) wraps UartRegisterMap. Whole-register and individual-field access both work:

```
from cdc_demo import CdcDemoDriver
d = CdcDemoDriver(port="/dev/ttyUSB1")          # or bridge=... for sim

d.build_id()                                    # -> 0x43434331
```

```
d.scratch(0xDEADBEEF)                                  # write + read back
d.disp_select(2)                                       # DISP_SELECT.sel = 2

c = d.counter(2)
c.set_cdc_mode(2)                                      #
COUNTER2_CDC_MODE.mode = 2
c.set_div_pickoff(23)                                  # DIVISOR.
{clock_select=4, div_pickoff=23}
c.set_init(0x10); c.set_increment(3); c.load()         # load INIT
c.press()                                              # HOST_PRESS
c.value(), c.press_count()                             # CDC'd status
readback
```

Packed fields are spliced by name with a read-modify-write, so setting `div_pickoff` never disturbs `clock_select`. Write-only strobes (`CFG_LOAD`, `HOST_PRESS`) are writable by name but read back as 0 by design.

6.4 Regenerating the regmap

`rtl/cdc_demo_harness.sv` is hand-written; the RDL is a descriptor of it. After editing either the SV or the RDL:

```
make regmap        # regenerate dv/tbclasses/cdc_demo_csr_regmap.py
from the RDL
make consistency   # assert regmap == SV (globals + reconstructed per-
counter)
```

Never hand-edit the generated regmap — it is regenerated from the RDL.

7 Simulation / Silicon Equivalence

This project follows the shared Nexys A7 UART-characterization methodology (`bin/TBClasses/harness/`): **one authored-once host program runs byte-for-byte identically on the FPGA and in a cocotb simulation.** The equivalence boundary is the ASCII `W/R` byte stream on the UART wire — if the same program emits the same bytes, the same `uart_axil_bridge` RTL decodes them the same way on silicon and in sim.

7.1 The layered stack (only the bottom layer differs)

```
Programs   cdc_programs.py            authored once, unchanged
FPGA/sim
Driver     CdcDemoDriver + UartRegisterMap   by-name registers
Protocol   UARTAxiBridge (W/R ASCII)  same code both sides
-- byte stream
------------------------------------------------------------
Channel    SerialChannel (pyserial)  |  CocotbUartChannel (cocotb)
Wire       FTDI/USB UART             |  UARTMaster/Monitor on DUT pins
```

The bridge is **injectable**: `CdcDemoDriver(port=...)` opens a real serial port; `CdcDemoDriver(bridge=UARTAxiBridge(channel=cocotb_channel))` drives the sim. Nothing above the wire forks.

7.2 How the sim runs the same program

`dv/tb/cdc_demo_uart_tb_top.sv` wraps the **real** `uart_axil_bridge` + `cdc_demo_harness` + four `cdc_counter_domain` instances. `dv/tests/test_cdc_demo_uart.py`:

1. Starts `aclk` and reset, and drives the four `ctr_clk[i]` at co-prime periods.
2. Builds a `CocotbUartChannel` via `make_uart_channel(dut, dut.aclk, CLKS_PER_BIT)`.
3. Constructs `CdcDemoDriver(bridge=UARTAxiBridge(channel=chan))`.
4. Runs the unmodified `cdc_programs.*` functions inside `cocotb.external(...)`.

The synchronous host program runs in a worker thread; the channel's read/write are `cocotb.function` wrappers that drive the UART master and advance simulation time. The four cocotb tests (smoke, press, cfg_load, cdc_mode) assert the same results the CLI checks on the board.

7.3 What the sim can and cannot reproduce

- **CAN:** everything digital — the bridge RTL, CSR decode, per-counter CDC datapaths, register logic. The sim proves the byte protocol and the harness contract before you ever touch the board.

- **CANNOT:** the analog clock tree. `cdc_demo_top`'s `MMCME2_BASE` / `BUFGMUX_CTRL` / `IBUF` / `BUFG` do not simulate in Verilator, so the tb_top drives `ctr_clk[i]` behaviorally instead. Consequently the NO-CDC "garbage read" is a silicon-only effect — in Verilator (no metastability) mode 0 reads the true value, so the sim asserts exact values in NO-CDC while the board shows scramble at speed.

7.4 Gotchas worth keeping

- **Lower `CLKS_PER_BIT` in sim** (16, in both the tb_top param and the BFM) — bit-timing only, the byte stream is unchanged, so equivalence holds.
- **Wrap the full harness, not the inner block** — the real `uart_axil_bridge` + `cdc_demo_harness` must be in the DUT, or the two flows are only "vaguely similar," not equivalent.
- **Use `cocotb.function`, not a free-running pump** — a pump coroutine plus thread queues stalls the scheduler; `cocotb.function` is what steps the sim from worker-thread calls.

8 Troubleshooting

8.1 The host CLI cannot find the board

The USB-UART re-enumerates across reboots and replugs, so the port number drifts. The CLI defaults to `--port auto`, which resolves the port through the shared board layer: it narrows to this board's ports by USB serial (the board registry in `projects/fpga-systems/bin/boards/` knows the FTDI serial) and keeps the one that answers `BUILD_ID == 0x43434331` ("CDC1"). If autodetect fails:

- Confirm the board is powered and programmed with the **demo** bitstream (`make program`), not build-phase1.
- Run `make ports` to see which ttyUSB this board is on right now, and `make board-info` for the registry's serial. A swapped board unit shows up as "no UART ports found" quoting a serial that is no longer attached.
- Check the FTDI cable and that no other program holds the port.
- Force a specific device with `--port /dev/ttyUSB1` (still probed, so a stale path fails loudly instead of driving the wrong board).

8.2 Values look scrambled / never settle

Expected in **NO-CDC mode at a fast clock** — that is the demonstration. For coherent reads, put the counter in a safe `CDC_MODE` (2 = SYNC-FIFO, or 3/4 for the handshakes) before reading `VALUE`. `PRESS_COUNT` always uses Gray-coded CDC and is coherent regardless of mode.

8.3 `make lint` — Xilinx primitive errors

`cdc_demo_top` instantiates `MMCME2_BASE` / `BUFGMUX_CTRL` / `IBUF` / `BUFG`, which Verilator cannot find. The shared stub file (`projects/components/utility-ip/misc/rtl/verilator_xilinx_stubs.sv`, pulled in through its filelist by `build-demo/rtl/filelists/cdc_demo_top.f`) provides `` `ifdef VERILATOR ``-guarded pass-through stubs (Vivado uses the real unisims at synthesis; the create_project tcl drops the stub file from the project). If lint fails with "Cannot find module" for one of these, confirm the stub filelist is still included in the build's `.f` closure.

8.4 `make sim BUILD=phase1` fails to compile

Phase 1 uses `clock_divider.sv`, which relies on the `` `ALWAYS_FF_RST `` macro from `rtl/amba/includes/reset_defs.svh`. The build's filelist (`build-phase1/rtl/filelists/cdc_counter_display_top.f`) carries the `+incdir` and the reset-defs sub-filelist; the test resolves its sources from that same closure. If you see "Define or directive not defined: `ALWAYS_FF_RST`", that include entry is missing from the filelist.

8.5 `make consistency` fails after editing registers

The generated regmap drifted from the hand-written SV. Regenerate and re-check:

```
make regmap
make consistency
```

If it still fails, the SV header table or the `CTR_OFF_*` localparams in `cdc_demo_harness.sv` disagree with `build-demo/rtl/cdc_demo_csr.rdl` — reconcile the three.

8.6 Sim runs but nothing advances

If a UART-equivalence test hangs, the transport is almost certainly using a pump instead of `cocotb.function`, or `CLKS_PER_BIT` was left at the silicon value (868), making each command hundreds of thousands of clocks. Both are covered in Chapter 6.